

Scientist Network for Advancing Policy (SNAP)

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Policy Hackathon 2026

Policy <> Track L

Open Track — Design Your Own Scope

About This Track:

This challenge is part of the Policy Hackathon 2026 L track: Open Track. Scope your own policy problem, then move through the same analysis-and-briefing structure.

Use Case Description:

For teams who already have a policy issue they care about that doesn't fit neatly into the other tracks, or who want the challenge of scoping their own problem the way a real fellow does in the first weeks of a placement. The team's first deliverable is the scope itself — defined, justified, and bounded — before moving into the same analysis-and-briefing structure as the other tracks.

Problem Statement:

Scoping your own policy problem before moving into full analysis and briefing.

- Identify a policy problem in any domain — can combine or cut across the other tracks.
- Write a one-paragraph problem statement and justify why it matters and why now.
- Define scope boundaries explicitly: jurisdiction, timeframe, and population/stakeholders affected. State what's out of scope and why.
- Get scope approved by an instructor/judge/mentor before proceeding.
- Proceed through the same core policy tasks as any track: landscape/stakeholder mapping, options analysis, recommendation, tradeoffs.

Possible Approaches:

- Cross-track fusion — deliberately combine two tracks' subject areas into one proposal.
- Hyper-local — scope down to a single city, campus, or agency rather than state/national level.
- Personal-experience — start from a problem the team has direct experience with.
- Frontier-issue — pick something genuinely unsettled that doesn't have an established policy playbook yet.

Challenge Duration:

- Teams start working in September 2026
- Submission on **November 14, 2026**. There will be no extension to the submission deadline.

Team Guidelines:

- Team size — **3–5 participants per team, interdisciplinary encouraged.**
- Ensure you are enrolled as a participant in Policy Hackathon 2026.
- Everyone is eligible to participate in this challenge and win awards.
- Standout teams may be invited to brief partner organizations or judges directly on their proposal.

Challenge Tasks / Deliverables:

- Scope memo (1 page): problem statement, jurisdiction, timeframe, stakeholders, explicit out-of-scope boundaries — submitted and approved before full work begins
- 4–6 page policy brief (same standard as other tracks)
- One-page fact sheet / leave-behind
- Slide deck (8–10 slides)

Optional Advanced Tasks:

- Same menu as other tracks (model legislative text, interactive dashboard, interviews, dissenting-view memo, etc.) — team selects what fits
- A short reflection on why they scoped the problem the way they did and what they deliberately excluded

Platforms and Tools:

- Same general categories as other tracks — team selects tools appropriate to their chosen domain.
- Teams are encouraged to identify their own authoritative data source(s) as part of the scoping step.

Judging Criteria:

- Quality and defensibility of the scope itself — **20%**
- Policy feasibility & rigor — **25%**
- Clarity & persuasiveness of writing/briefing — **20%**
- Stakeholder analysis depth — **15%**
- Originality of problem selection — **10%**
- Handling of tradeoffs/edge cases — **10%**

Data Privacy / Eligibility Restriction:

- Same baseline rules as all other tracks: public/cite-able sources only, no non-public government or proprietary data.
- Informed consent and anonymization for any interviews; AI tool use disclosed in an appendix.
- Team is responsible for flagging domain-specific data-sensitivity issues (health data, minors, national security) in the scope memo.

Participants retain ownership of their submissions but grant Scientist Network for Advancing Policy (SNAP) the right to evaluate, discuss, and showcase submitted work for educational and research purposes, with appropriate attribution.